

Subject: Interest in joining your group as a graduate student

I hope this email finds you well. I am writing to introduce myself and to express my interest in joining your research group.

My name is Renato La Torre, a Peruvian biologist interested in Genomics and Bioinformatics for studying biodiversity through space and time. I am interested in Neotropical diversity and what genomes can tell us about species' adaptation, current status, and adaptability in face of rapid climate change. While unveiling exciting big questions, my goal is to contribute to conservation to reverse the alarming trends of extinction.

This year I obtained a MSc degree in Norway at NTNU with Dr. Mike Martin, earning the highest grade for my thesis on the paleogenomics of a Peruvian keystone species, the huarango tree (*Neltuma/Prosopis limensis*), and how human deforestation impacted their genetic diversity ([thesis](#)). This led to some interesting findings about their adaptation and response to population decline, important for understanding their current critical endangerment. For this, I used a chromosome-level reference genome that I was responsible for assembling with my group ([article](#)): the first high-resolution assembly of a wild species for Peru. I also led sedaDNA analyses for paleoecological reconstruction in a Norwegian excavation ([preprint](#)). Currently I am looking to submit the manuscripts for these projects, while working and applying to graduate programs this year.

I am motivated to pursue a PhD with a project regarding Neotropical plant genomics, particularly including Peru, an understudied region with a rich diversity. I was excited to read about your lab research, mission and culture, and I think it would be a great environment for deepening my interests while keeping enjoying science and acquiring new valuable skills. Your studies at multiple levels and across different disciplines, guided by a core question, is fascinating to me, and I think I would enjoy it since I love discussing and involving myself in my colleagues' projects and interests. Similarly, I am creative and have tons of ideas which I would be passionate to discuss in a group. I communicate with multiple stakeholders here that align with my passion about conservation and would facilitate resources for carrying out big projects. In the future, I hope to keep contributing to both understanding and conserving more of the Neotropical diversity through genomics and bioinformatics.

I would like to ask if you believe I would be a good fit for your laboratory and if there is a possibility for me to apply to UC Berkeley this year. I would love to have a conversation if you have time, I am available in Peru time (GMT -5). I attach my CV and [site](#) for reference.

Thank you very much for your attention. Kind regards,

Renato